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The Supreme Court's decision to annul the amnesty over corruption cases against Zardari is likely to be his political epitaph

| By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi |

Ironically, in a country coping with almost daily terrorist attacks and a full-fledged war against a deadly insurgency, the biggest bombshell has been a political one, and it has just exploded. While it may not have caused physical injury and destruction, the shockwaves from this explosion are certain to alter the face of current politics in Pakistan and is likely to spell political doom for President Asif Ali Zardari. In a landmark judgement handed down unanimously on December 16 by all 17 judges of Pakistan's Supreme Court, the court retrospectively annulled the controversial National Reconciliation Ordinance (NRO) from the time of its promulgation by former President General Pervez Musharraf on October 5, 2007.

The NRO, which had come into effect on the eve of General Musharraf's re-election as head of state while still in uniform, had been widely perceived as brokered by the US administration and as the General's quid pro quo with slain Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) leader Benazir Bhutto for her tacit support for his staying in power. The US was, at the time, attempting not only to bolster its ally General Musharraf but also to bring the 'secular' and 'liberal' forces onto the same platform to aid it in its fight against Islamist militancy. Like any decree that was never given a stamp of approval by Parliament and thus



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